years, to ascertain if their contracts with the US company invariably had such conditions. The information the company shared helped TASL to sign the contract without this onerous provision.

In a bid that could have changed the defence–industrial landscape of the nation and the company, TASL signed an agreement with Lockheed Martin to produce and market the new generation of the F-16 Block 70 supersonic multi-role aircraft if it won the large contract from the Indian Air Force for 100 platforms. Ratan, who had himself flown this aircraft, was impressed with its potential. It could have resulted in $15 bn of export orders for the aircraft, besides making TASL the ‘hub for all service and support requirements of the F-16 fleet worldwide’, wrote a business daily. The company had also proposed transferring the plane’s production centre from Texas to India.

Though TASL lost the F-16 race to Rafale of France, it remained positioned to contribute immensely to the nation’s defence effort whenever it won a large contract for production of defence platforms in India. In such cases, TASL would have the advantage of the synergy it can forge with the numerous specialized group companies, such as TCS.

In 2018, Tata Sons consolidated its various businesses in the defence sector under Tata Aerospace and Defence (Tata A&D) to draw synergies from entities across the group. The Manufacturing Solutions Ltd, a subsidiary of Tata Motors; the strategic engineering division of Tata Power; Tata Advanced Materials Ltd, a subsidiary of Tata Industries; and TASL came together to form the new entity. With a combined revenue of nearly Rs 3,600 crore, the new entity would be able to play a more focused role in Indian defence, says Singh. In the press release, N. Chandrasekaran said that the newly formed Tata A&D would help the group to ‘better target emerging opportunities in aerospace and defence and engage holistically with customers both in India and globally’.

Multiple Capabilities

TASL has four subsidiaries—Tata Advanced Materials Limited (TAML), TAL Manufacturing Solutions Limited, TASEC Limited and NOVA Integrated Systems. While TAML focuses on ‘composite manufacturing and solutions’ and caters to the demands of space, defence, aerospace and industrial composites across the globe, TAL Manufacturing Solutions, a